Chapter 4

Tara the Otter

Tara is a young otter. She lives with her family on the bank of a river in the forest. Otters are small animals with thick brown fur, short legs and a long, strong tail. Their feet are webbed, like a duck's feet, which helps them swim fast. When an otter dives under water, it can close its ears and its nose so that water does not get in.

Tara's family lives in a den, which is a hole dug into the river bank. Every morning the family goes fishing together. Otters eat fish, crabs and frogs. Tara is still learning to catch fish, so her mother catches most of them for her.

But more than anything else, Tara loves to play. She slides down the muddy river bank on her tummy and lands in the water with a big splash. Then she climbs up and does it again and again. She also loves to play with pebbles. She lies on her back, holds a smooth pebble on her chest and tosses it from paw to paw. Sometimes she chases her little brother through the water until they are both tired.

One afternoon, Tara swam far away from her den. She saw something shiny near the river bank and swam closer. It was an old fishing net that someone had thrown into the river. Before she knew it, her paw was caught in the net. The more she pulled, the tighter it became. Tara squeaked loudly for help.

Kiran and her friends were walking near the river. They heard the squeaks and saw the little otter caught in the net. Kiran knew that a wild animal may bite when it is scared, so she did not touch Tara. Instead, she ran to call the forest guard. The forest guard came quickly with a pair of scissors. Gently, he cut the net and set Tara free. Tara dived into the water and swam back home to her family.

The next Sunday, Kiran and her friends cleaned the river bank. They picked up plastic bags, bottles and old nets so that no other animal would get hurt.

Let's talk

1. How do webbed feet help an otter?
2. What games did Tara like to play?
3. Why did Kiran call the forest guard instead of helping Tara herself?

New words

den - the home of a wild animal
webbed - joined by thin skin between the toes